along the riverbanks even after a Union government ban in 2019, because the fish is easy to rear and has a ready market.

The tide, though, may finally be turning. The BNHS is helming the Ujani Wetland Eco-restoration and Fisheries Development Program, the first such initiative in South Asia to involve local communities in removing invasive fish such as suckermouth and reintroducing indigenous fingerlings into the Ujani. The BNHS is also working to get the dam notified as a Ramsar site, which would give the ecosystem a higher level of protection. Meanwhile, the administration is cracking down on illegal Mangur farming.

Return of the Native

The Ujani project is based on incentivising local fishermen to remove invasive fish species. They are paid an additional Rs 2 per kg over the market price—around Rs 38 per kg—for handing over suckermouths at a designated collection centre in Bhigwan. Since the project was launched in April, some 38 tonnes of the spiny fish have been collected and sold to industries in Maharashtra that manufacture fish feed, fish oil and liquid fertiliser. The programme aims to eliminate suckermouths by the end of 2027-28, especially since it has begun infiltrating river systems originating in the Sahyadris, a biodiversity hotspot in the Western Ghats. Suckermouth has been found upstream at Bhimashankar, where the Bhima river, on which the Ujani dam is located, originates, as well as in the Krishna basin. As for the tilapia, Vijay Shikhare, regional deputy commissioner, fisheries, says soon there "may not be a single water body [in the Pune region] that does not have it". Their proliferation in freshwater bodies connected to the dam has also contributed to the depletion of other local fish such as Nukta (Nukta nukta), which is now restricted to pockets such as Veer dam in Pune and areas downstream of Solapur.

Alongside eliminating invasive fish species, the Ujani project will reintroduce indigenous fish and plants. By January 2027, around 4.2 million fingerlings of native species such as Deccan mahseer, rohu and catla will be released, along with endemic and endangered varieties like Bobri, Kolshi and Khavlya. In 2027, around 60-70 million spawn will be introduced. According to Katwate, reintroducing endemic and previously lost fish species will create competition for ecological niches between them and invasive species. Local breeds, claims fisherman-activist Bharat Mallav, who heads the Ambika Fisheries Cooperative Society in Bhigwan, will also be healthier to consume since their feeding habits ensure lower heavy-metal accumulation in their bodies.

The BNHS is also working on reintroducing otters, which once dominated the basin, to help control tilapia and suckermouth populations. To improve ecosystem management and naturally reduce water pollution, around 21,000 native aquatic plants—including vallisneria, native lily, sweet flag and vetiver—will be planted along the banks, along with some 500,000 Indian lotus plants.

Simultaneously, there has been a crackdown on illicit Mangur farming, with 12 of them shut down so far and their stocks destroyed. Solapur district collector Karthikeyan S. says the administration is using a three-pronged strategy: "We will eradicate the existing stock of invasive breeds, re-introduce *desi* species like the mahseer and also create a local economy for it." To that end, companies manufacturing products such as fish oil have been invited to set up units in the industrial estates in Solapur. Sport fishing and recreational angling of mahseer will also be encouraged as part of a larger project to promote water-based tourism in Ujani.



"We are not just losing many of these indigenous fish species... entire generations are growing up unaware of our biodiversity"

UNMESH KATWATE
Senior Scientist and Assistant Director, BNHS



"Sport fishing and recreational angling of the Mahseer will be introduced as part of the larger project to promote water-based tourism in the Ujani"

KARTHIKEYAN S.
District Collector, Solapur

Casting the Net Wider

The administration will also implement the ban on mosquito nets for fishing. Used by migrant fishermen for bottom trawling—'*vadap*', in local parlance—their fine mesh makes it impossible for fingerlings and fish larvae to escape. This, says Bharat Mallav, had undermined previous efforts by the government and his own team to stabilise fish populations by releasing indigenous fingerlings in the dam. Now, CCTVs, camera traps, thermal cameras and alarm systems will be deployed to enforce the crackdown.

However, wholesaler Ankush Wagh fears eradicating the tilapia will also have its cost. The fish is now a vital source of livelihood for local fishermen, and restaurants even advertise their signature 'tilapia fry'. "There was a time," says Mallav, "when fishermen would return the small *chilapi* [as tilapia is known in these parts] caught in their nets back to the water. Not anymore...now they have no option but to sell them, since few other fish are available." For now, BNHS director Kishor Rithe sees great promise in the pilot project. He also believes it could be a template for similar pan-India initiatives. The plan, he says, is to work with other governments to restore at least one wetland in every state, systematically reaching 400 priority sites across the country. ■